

Managing Arthritis Fatigue – A UK Guide

Fatigue affects 70% of people with arthritis. UK guide to understanding why arthritis causes tiredness and practical strategies for energy management.

By **Living With Arthritis Editorial Team** · Reviewed by **Clinical Advisory Panel** (HCPC-registered physiotherapy & rheumatology nursing input) · 2026-02-15 · livingwitharthritis.org.uk

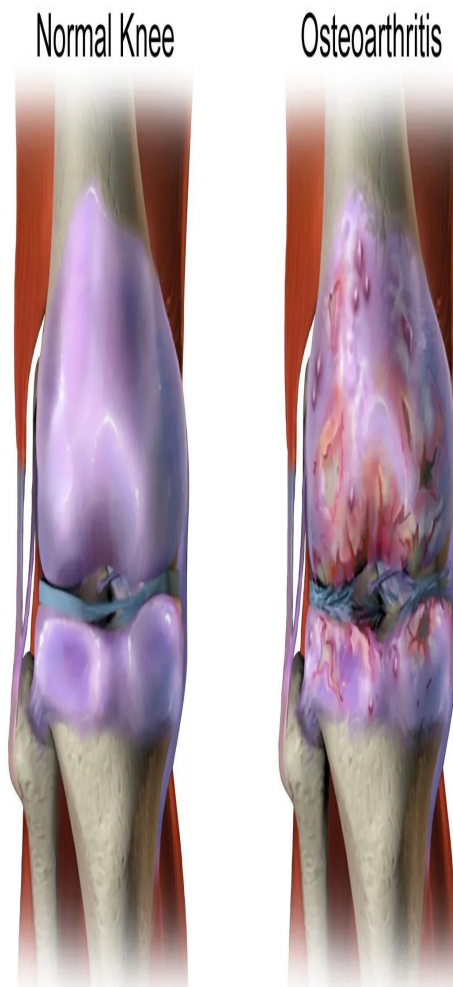
Fatigue is one of the most common and disabling symptoms of arthritis, yet it's often overlooked. Up to **70% of people with inflammatory arthritis** report significant fatigue that affects their daily lives — and it's not just feeling tired.

What Is Arthritis Fatigue?

Arthritis fatigue is different from normal tiredness. It's an overwhelming, whole-body exhaustion that:

- Doesn't improve fully with rest or sleep
 - Can be as debilitating as the pain itself
 - Affects concentration, mood, and motivation
 - Can strike suddenly or build throughout the day
 - Makes simple tasks feel overwhelmingly difficult
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Why Does Arthritis Cause Fatigue?



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- Inflammation — cytokines released during inflammation directly cause fatigue
- Pain — chronic pain is mentally and physically exhausting
- Poor sleep — pain disrupts sleep quality, even if you sleep long hours
- Anaemia — common in inflammatory arthritis, reducing oxygen delivery
- Medications — some arthritis drugs cause fatigue as a side effect
- Reduced fitness — deconditioning from reduced activity
- Emotional burden — living with chronic illness is emotionally draining

The 5 P's of Energy Management

1. Prioritise

Decide what's most important each day. You don't have to do everything.

2. Plan

Spread demanding activities across the week. Don't schedule heavy tasks on consecutive days.

3. Pace

Break tasks into smaller chunks with rest periods. The "20-minute rule" — do 20 minutes of activity, then rest for 10.

4. Position

Sit rather than stand where possible. Use perching stools, trolleys, and aids to reduce effort.

5. Permission

Give yourself permission to rest without guilt. Fatigue is a real symptom, not laziness.

When to See Your GP



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Talk to your GP if:

- Fatigue is worsening or not improving with self-management
- You have other symptoms like unexplained weight loss, fever, or breathlessness
- Your current medication might be contributing to fatigue
- You want to be checked for anaemia or thyroid problems (common co-conditions)

Practical Tips

- Exercise regularly — it sounds counterintuitive, but regular activity improves energy long-term
- Eat regular, balanced meals — avoid sugar crashes
- Stay hydrated — dehydration worsens fatigue

- Limit caffeine after 2pm — it can disrupt sleep
- Ask for help — delegate tasks to family, friends, or support services
- Consider an OT assessment — they specialise in energy management

Fatigue is a legitimate and significant symptom of arthritis. Don't dismiss it, and don't let others dismiss it either. Discuss it with your healthcare team.

Q&A

Question: What Is Arthritis Fatigue?

Short answer: Arthritis fatigue is different from normal tiredness. It's an overwhelming, whole-body exhaustion that: Doesn't improve fully with rest or sleep Can be as debilitating as the pain itself Affects concentration, mood, and motivation Can strike suddenly or build throughout the day Makes simple tasks feel overwhelmingly difficult

Question: Why Does Arthritis Cause Fatigue?

Short answer: Inflammation — cytokines released during inflammation directly cause fatigue Pain — chronic pain is mentally and physically exhausting Poor sleep — pain disrupts sleep quality, even if you sleep long hours Anaemia — common in inflammatory arthritis, reducing oxygen delivery Medications — some arthritis drugs cause fatigue as a side effect Reduced fitness — deconditioning from reduced activity Emotional burden — living with chronic illness is emot

General information only — not medical advice. Consult your GP or specialist before changing medication or starting a new programme. Emergency: 999. NHS advice: 111. Living With Arthritis UK · livingwitharthritis.org.uk